

medication, isotretinoin, which is taken orally, may increase the risk of birth defects and is therefore contraindicated in pregnancy.

I'm in the first trimester and will be going to my sister's wedding. Can I have highlights put in my hair?

Although the research into the safety of hair dyes if used in the first trimester may seem conflicting, the amount of chemicals used is small and it's unlikely that hair dyes cause harm. Also, if your hairdresser uses foil, the dye is kept off your skin.

I've heard that nail polish needs to be removed if you have a cesarean. Why is this?

Previously, women were encouraged to remove nail polish before surgery. One of the reasons was that the "pulse oximeter," a device attached to your finger to measure the oxygen in your blood during surgery, may give lower readings if placed over nail polish. However the device works as intended with nail polish or long nails if it's mounted sideways on a finger. Therefore there's no need to remove your polish.

BEAUTY TREATMENTS AND COSMETICS

Hair and nail products Shampoos, conditioners, manicures, and pedicures are safe. Minute amounts of hair dye may be absorbed through the skin, but there's no evidence that this affects the baby. Chemical hair straighteners and curlers are also thought to be safe.

Piercing Facial piercing or piercing the belly button, nipples, or genitalia isn't advised since you're at a higher risk of infection. If you have a navel piercing already, you can change a metallic ring for a flexible plastic retainer made from PTFE (polytetrafluoroethylene). Nipple rings can affect breast-feeding, so remove a ring before birth so the skin can heal. Vaginal or vulval piercings are best removed to avoid damage at birth.

Tanning Tanning beds aren't advised because of harmful UV rays. Tanning beds can cause your body to overheat, which can harm your baby, and UV rays may break down folic acid. Tanning lotions are safe.

Body wraps/ Hot tubs These raise body temperature, which is unsafe for you and your baby. Heat exposure from a hot tub in the first three months can increase the risk of a baby developing spina bifida.

Facials The cosmetics used for facials are thought to be safe.

Botox The Food and Drug Administration recommends that women who are pregnant or breastfeeding should not use Botox. Although it's used for cosmetic reasons, it is a drug and should be considered as such. Doctors also advise against having Botox during pregnancy.